

Glossary



Artists' colors

The highest quality watercolor paints, these contain more fine pigment than students' colors, so produce the most permanent results. They are also more transparent, which means they create more luminous paintings.

Backruns

Irregular shapes, sometimes called blooms, caused when paint in one color flows into another color that hasn't fully dried. The marks produced have dark outer edges.

Broken wash

A wash produced by letting a loaded brush glance over the top of the paper as it is drawn across it, so that areas of white paper show through.

Cold-pressed paper

Paper with a slightly textured surface that has been pressed by cold rather than hot rollers during its manufacture. It is sometimes called NOT paper.

Color mix

Paint that has completely dissolved in water to make a pool of color.

Color wheel

A visual device for showing the relationship between primary, secondary, and intermediate colors.

Complementary colors

Colors that are located directly opposite each other on the color wheel. The complementary of any secondary color is the primary

color that it does not contain.

Green, for example, is mixed from blue and yellow so its complementary is red.

Composition

The design of a painting, which takes into account the main areas of focus and the balance of interest.

Cool colors

Colors with a bluish tone.

Cool colors appear to recede in a painting, so can be used to help create perspective.

Dry brushwork

Loading a brush with very little paint and dragging it over the dry paper's surface to produce broken marks. The method is useful for creating texture.

Feathering

Painting lines with water then adding strokes of color over the top at an angle. The strokes of color are softened as the paint bleeds along the water lines.

Flat wash

A wash produced by painting overlapping bands of the same color so that a smooth layer of uniform color is produced.

Focal point

The main area of interest in a composition. In paintings, it is the place where the lightest and darkest marks meet.

Format

The shape of the paper. Commonly used formats are landscape, portrait, and square.

